

Aor Vahra ### A Bedtime Story for Brave Young Explorers

Chapter One ? The Boy Who Followed the Little Light

Long ago, past the last hill where the streetlights stop and the stars begin, there was a land that only woke up when children went to sleep.

It was called Aor Vahra, which means the Land of the Gentle Light.

Most grown-ups had forgotten all about it. But boys and girls who were brave enough ? and just sleepy enough ? could still find the way. You had to be the kind of kid who wasn't afraid of the dark, but liked to whisper to it, just in case it whispered back.

This is the story of a boy named Wren, and the very first night he found it.

Wren was tucked into bed with his blanket pulled up to his chin. The house was quiet. Outside his window, the moon was round and yellow like a button.

He was almost, almost asleep? when he saw it.

A little light.

It was small ? no bigger than a firefly ? and it floated right in the middle of his room, bobbing up and down as if it were trying to make up its mind. It glowed a soft, warm gold, the color of a candle, and when it moved, it left a trail of tiny sparkles that melted in the air like snowflakes.

"Hello?" Wren whispered.

The little light bobbed twice. Bob, bob. Almost like it was saying yes.

Wren sat up slowly. He was not scared. He was the kind of boy who liked to whisper to the dark, remember? And the little light seemed friendly ? a bit lost, maybe, but friendly.

"Are you looking for someone?" he asked.

The light floated to the window and pressed against the glass, like a puppy that wants to go outside. Then it looked back at Wren, as if to say, Come on. Please?

So Wren did the bravest thing he had done all week.

He got out of bed.

The moment his feet touched the floor, something wonderful happened.

The walls of his room went soft and silvery, like fog. The window swung open all on its own with a tiny squeak, and instead of his backyard, Wren saw a path.

It was a path made of moonlight ? actual moonlight, spilled across the grass like a river of milk ? and it led down, down, down past the last hill, all the way to a forest that glowed.

Every tree had leaves that shimmered. Every flower held a drop of light, like a little lamp. And high above it all, the stars hung so low that Wren felt he could reach up and stir them with his finger.

"Whoa," he breathed.

The little light zipped out the window and waited on the path, bobbing impatiently.

Wren stepped out after it. The grass was cool and the air smelled like rain and honey. And the funny thing was ? he wasn't cold at all, even in his pajamas.

"Okay," he said to the little light. "Lead the way."

They walked together down the moonlit path, the boy and the little light, deeper into the glowing forest.

As they went, Wren began to notice things.

He noticed that the trees leaned in gently as he passed, the way kind grown-ups lean down to listen to you. He noticed soft sounds in the dark ? not scary ones, but cozy ones. A faraway lullaby. The hush of leaves. Something that might have been a sleepy giant, snoring far over the hills.

And he noticed that his little light was getting dimmer.

"Hey," Wren said softly. "Are you alright?"

The light flickered. It dropped a little lower, the way you droop when you're very, very tired. Its warm gold glow had faded to the pale color of morning.

That was when Wren understood.

The little light wasn't leading him anywhere on purpose. It was lost. It had wandered too far from home, the way a small thing sometimes does, and now it didn't have enough glow left to find its way back.

It hadn't come to scare him. It had come to ask for help.

Wren knelt down on the path and held out his cupped hands.

"It's okay," he whispered. "I've got you. We'll find your home. I'm good at finding things."

The little light drifted into his palms and rested there, no heavier than a feather, blinking up at him.

And right then ? because that is exactly how Aor Vahra works ? a new path

appeared.

It wasn't made of moonlight this time. It was made of all the other little lights, far off in the deep of the forest, switching on one by one to show the way. Hundreds of them. Thousands. A whole gentle galaxy hidden between the trees, all waiting for one small lost light to come home.

Wren grinned in the dark.

He stood up, holding his little light close so it would stay warm, and he took his first step toward the deep of the forest, where the home of all the lights was waiting.

But that ? my brave young explorer ? is a story for tomorrow night.

Because right now, the little light is safe.

And so are you.

Goodnight.

End of Chapter One.